gress president Sonia Gandhi.

The Congress is now banking on the octogenarian, who edged past Shashi Tharoor to win the presidential poll, to take the party out of the worst political crisis in its 136-year history—two humiliating Lok Sabha defeats and 42 losses in 50 assembly elections held since 2014. The party is in power in only two of India's 30 states and its legislative strength in Parliament is in the mid double digits—53 members in the Lok Sabha and a mere 31 in the Rajya Sabha.

It isn't going to be an easy ride. Kharge may have been elected captain, but he will have to constantly battle the perception that he is perhaps a remote-controlled president. For the first time in Congress history, three people of the Gandhi family—Sonia, Rahul and Priyanka—are active in politics, while a non-Gandhi is party in-charge.

His detractors claim Kharge will be a mere rubber stamp, that it will be business as usual, with the Family now relieved of accountability for the party's disastrous poll performances. "If the Gandhi family has become a liability, then Kharge is not the answer. He is one of the *darbari*s and will serve their interest, not of the party," says a young Congress Lok Sabha MP.

Many insiders assert that it's this very unflinching loyalty to the "interests of the Gandhis" that made him their "unofficially official" candidate for president. In his 53-year association with the Congress, Kharge has never showed any streak of rebellion except for a brief period of less than a year when in 1979, he had left the Congress along with mentor and ex-Karnataka CM Devaraj Urs. He did not express resentment even when he was denied the opportunity to become chief minister, and this happened thrice. In 1999, S.M. Krishna pipped him to the post. In 2004, close friend Dharam Singh became the consensus candidate to head a Congress-Janata Dal (Secular) coalition. In 2013, Siddaramaiah edged him out.

But at a time when the family's authority itself seems to be diminishing, will it make Kharge a "weak president"? In the past eight years, he was their chosen emissary to resolve internal power disputes in Assam, Punjab and Rajasthan, but wasn't able to deliver favourable outcomes anywhere. In July 2014, he was sent to Assam as an observer when then CM Tarun Gogoi was battling dissent from trusted lieutenant Himanta Biswa Sarma. Of the 78 party MLAs in the state, 54 gave Kharge a signed document saying they did not want Gogoi to continue. Nobody knows what report Kharge gave to the high command, but Gogoi kept his chair. A year later, Sarma joined the BJP and has since then been instrumental in rooting out the Congress not just from Assam but from other Northeast states as well.

In June 2021, Kharge headed a three-member panel set up to solve the internal squabbles in the Punjab Congress, particularly between then CM Amarinder Singh and Navjot Singh Sidhu. Kharge was ineffective and, eventually, Amarinder was asked to quit as chief minister while Sidhu was made Punjab Congress president. The final result: the party was decimated in the assembly polls earlier this year, Amarinder has joined the BJP and Sidhu is in jail, convicted in a three-decade-old case.

The latest fiasco happened last month when Kharge, along with All India Congress Committee in-charge of Rajasthan Ajay Maken, landed in Jaipur to get a one-line resolution passed by party MLAs, authorising Congress president Sonia Gandhi to select the next chief minister of the state. This was because Ashok Gehlot was the first choice of the Gandhis to contest the party's presidential poll. Gehlot was required to resign as CM, upholding the party's Udaipur resolution from May of a 'one person, one post' policy. Kharge and Maken kept waiting at Gehlot's residence, where a meeting of the Congress legislature



AFTER THE WIN Sonia Gandhi meets Kharge, Oct. 19

KHARGE'S TOP CHALLENGES

- **REVIVE THE PARTY ORGANISATION** and get the Congress ready for elections in 10 states, including Gujarat, Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh, and the Lok Sabha election in 2024
- **BUILD A NARRATIVE** to counter the ruling BJP and emerging challengers such as AAP
- **PROVE HIS INDEPENDENCE,** show that the new Congress chief is not remote-controlled by the Gandhis
- **RESOLVE THE BIG INTERNAL FRICTIONS**—Gehlot vs Pilot in Rajasthan, Baghel vs Singhdeo in Chhattisgarh and Siddaramaiah vs D.K. Shivakumar in Karnataka
- **STOP FURTHER ATTRITION** in the party, create a balance between the old brigade and the young turks. Nurture regional leaders

IN THE PAST FEW YEARS, KHARGE HAD BEEN **THE CHOSEN EMISSARY TO RESOLVE INTERNAL PARTY DISPUTES** IN ASSAM, PUNJAB AND RAJASTHAN. HE COULDN'T DELIVER ANYWHERE